

in-life care. You may think they have a lot of money because they're only supporting themselves, but that's the problem. Unlike with Dave and Danielle, they don't have kids and grandkids who might be able to help out, drive them to the eye doctor, and pitch in financially now and again. They must take that into consideration long before they write a check to anyone, for anything.

As for Dave, you have to do what you can afford. Left with no other options, he applied for Medicaid; because of the couple's precarious financial situation, they were approved. Dave moved his wife to the nursing home Amanda and Lyle suggested. Luckily, the disease blunted some of the edges of her new reality, so she didn't mind living with roommates in a smaller, louder ward. Danielle died without knowing her family had been ripped apart over this.

Dealing with long-term care of our elderly is a decision that's always going to be fraught with emotions.

Money Mistake: You Haven't Set Anything Aside for Your Funeral

THE FIX: PREPLAN, EVEN IF YOU CAN'T PREPAY

The only industry more insidious than the wedding industry is the funeral industry. Both play heavily on your emotions at times when you need to be clear-minded and frugal. But the funeral industry is a special kind of evil, because wedding planning leaves a lot of time to think and second-guess every financial decision you make. When my mother died, it took us all by surprise. I was in shock, and that's the state most people are in when someone dies, even if it's expected. To say I regret not planning for my mother's funeral is an understatement. If you don't take on the planning yourself, you're putting your family through a wrenching experience at the worst possible time. When someone dies, thousands of dollars must be spent in a matter of hours. And, just as the cost of living will always increase, so, too, will the cost of dying.

The average funeral in this country costs \$10,000. That covers everything from transporting the body and embalming or cremating,